

Speaker 1 [00:00:05] I would like to know how you want us to refer to your partner, "boyfriend", "spouse", "partner", by their name. Is there a term you are most comfortable with?

Speaker 2 [00:00:19] My companion, you can say my companion or her first name [partner] as you... Companion or [partner].

Speaker 1 [00:00:25] Very well. How long have you been with your companion?

Speaker 2 [00:00:30] Since [Year]. End of [Year], so now it's been [20-25] years. It will be [20-25] years in [Month] exactly.

Speaker 1 [00:00:41] In [Month]. Listen, I would like first for you to tell me about the love story, that you are living with [partner], about your current relationship.

Speaker 2 [00:00:55] Hum. Well, listen, it's a, it's a quality relationship and rather harmonious, even though it can sometimes be dotted with a few small, claw marks or outbursts. But I think that's somewhat the fate of many couples. We met at the age of [26-30]. We are very similar because we are the same age, we are [6-10] days apart. I was born in [Month] and she was born in [Month] of the same year. We also built a family project as we have [1-5] children who are now [16-20], [11-15], and [11-15] years old. So there you go, and we are currently on family vacation, except our eldest who is working right now, but with the other boys. She is somehow my other half. I really consider her that way.

Speaker 1 [00:01:58] Yes, you said you were very similar.

Speaker 2 [00:02:03] Yes, very similar in temperaments, values, opinions, we resonate a lot. I think also that over time, we have rubbed off on each other. Maybe we indeed have gotten closer, or at least harmonized, let's say as the years went by. We have a good complicity. I believe we can say it like that, but we realize that we are, in quotes "quite rare". We have seen many couples around us break up and ours, for now, is still here. It works, what can I say.

Speaker 1 [00:02:48] You said harmonized?

Speaker 2 [00:02:52] Harmonized, yeah. We... We... I think our longevity works on the basis of communicating, a lot, in every sense of the word, by the way. You can split the word in two if you see what I mean. So we have good harmony in ideas, also in our intimacy... Yeah, on values, on manners, on what we pass on to our children, we are not too divergent from each other. So that's where I think that, with the passing years - I like this idea of rubbing off on each other, and on both sides of the coin, if you want. We resonate a lot in that. I personally resonate a lot in that anyway.

Speaker 1 [00:03:47] I would like you to tell me a bit about the circumstances of the meeting, how it happened, in what context, etc. Maybe go back a bit to the beginning.

Speaker 2 [00:03:58] We met through a mutual acquaintance, a work colleague. At the time, I was a [occupation] in a [company] and I had a colleague who had come to a party at my place, I was a student at the time. I was finishing my [educational attainment]. [partner] had been invited by a friend of this person. And so [partner] came to this party, at my place in [city] in my small apartment. And well, I was kind of single, more or less single, anyway a bit on the prowl at that time and so she caught my eye quite quickly. I sought to see her again, I got her contact information, I went to see her at her work she worked at [company] and little by little, I went to her place, and within a few weeks... There you go. We really got closer. That was in [Month] [Year]. Things progressed very quickly because [partner] was pregnant with our daughter in [Month] [Year]. So we didn't waste any time, in quotes.

Speaker 1 [00:05:12] I think someone is knocking at my door. Just a second. I'm really sorry.

Speaker 2 [00:05:15] Go ahead.

Speaker 1 [00:05:37] Someone's at the door. I'll just take two seconds, they are coming up and I'll be right back. I'm really sorry.

Speaker 1 [00:08:56] Thank you [participant]. I'm really sorry. There was a registered mail I had to pick up. Can you hear me? You are muted on your end. So wait, I can't hear you.

Speaker 2 [00:09:33] Can you hear me?

Speaker 1 [00:09:35] I hear you.

Speaker 2 [00:09:37] There we go, I have to reactivate. OK. Yes, I think it must cut off if we don't talk for a while.

Speaker 2 [00:09:42] Yes.

Speaker 1 [00:09:44] Yes, you were telling me about the conditions of the meeting. That she had come to your place, that it was a friend [ndt: who connected you] when you were a [occupation], that you had gotten closer, that she worked in a store.

Speaker 2 [00:09:58] So I wasn't professionally established, you know. I was a [occupation] in fact, a [occupation] in a [company], it was a scholarship we had. "Those were the good old days" in quotes, it's a shame that thing disappeared. And she was working as a [occupation] in a [company]. She placed [occupation] in tertiary jobs at [company] at the time. So there you go, she was working, I wasn't working, I was a semi-worker let's say. But we had the same years, the same age. Then I fell for her quite quickly. I don't know if she was into it at first, but she quickly fell for it too. But yes, we met in the [Year], in [Month]. I don't remember the exact date, but in the first half of [Month], we saw each other very quickly again. I went to her place quite quickly. Well, I remember we spent our first [Event] together, and we had only been together for [1-5] months, no more, no more.

Speaker 1 [00:11:03] So how did the rest of this interaction, this couple formation, unfold?

Speaker 2 [00:11:12] Well, it was quite a surprise. We were talking about it not long ago. As I told you, she got pregnant in [Month] and it coincided - I was losing my grandfather and I said "little steps replace big ones" because my grandfather passed away, [partner] got pregnant. Which was a big, big, big, big change for me, not so much for her, who I think might have been waiting for this. But not for me, so I was quite... We asked ourselves the question, you know. She told me "I don't force you into anything". But well, we did go to a center to know a bit about the decision... Well, what we were going to do, whether we were staying together, whether she was keeping it or not. She was ready to keep it, I didn't know. At the same time, the door was open. I think I somehow wanted to change my life. I wasn't quite ready yet, but then, sometimes life imposes itself on us. So I took the wave in quotes, and quite quickly we moved in together with this pregnancy coming. But there you go, we were a very new couple. We had very, very little time, very few months of experience together in fact, in the end. But by the summer, she left her apartment, I left mine to take a bigger one together. And then, I would say, our couple life continued. But yes, there was this event, this birth, this child [child's name], our daughter who came very, very quickly into our lives, in the end. So we were a couple, but quite quickly a parental couple somehow.

Speaker 1 [00:12:59] But quite quickly a parental couple. You mentioned earlier in the interview that in your couple, there were things that were not in other couples, especially this harmony, the fact of rubbing off on each other, that each takes attributes, characteristics of the other. I would like to know if you had to compare the quality of your relationship with that of your friends, what could you say?

Speaker 2 [00:13:32] Well already, each person is different. We are very similar, but we are very unique. So there you go, it makes effects obviously very, very different. Maybe what differentiates us is that we didn't give up, I think. We have known moments of great difficulty. We both asked ourselves questions, but we didn't give up. Probably for the children. Maybe also because we are deeply attached to each other, and so we didn't slam the door, you know. Maybe some of our friends' couples who separated had more differences between them. We had fewer, I really think. In values, we are closer, more similar. And yeah, we have no taboo subjects, we talk a lot. So it might allow for a slightly more tenacious longevity because... Yeah we communicate and there are no taboo subjects between us, we really talk a lot. So when there are crises, we argue, but then, there's always one or the other who comes back to the other. And so, there's this desire to continue the journey. For my part, I never... Sometimes I asked myself whether to stay or go, etc. But it was very rare. And when I reached this extreme idea, quite quickly in my mind, I backtracked because yeah, I was aware of the person I was with and what I would lose in fact. Maybe the fear of losing made us stay together but, that's not enough for a couple to hold well. So yeah, a deep attachment, I think, a deep respect for the other, a deep affection. I believe, in fact.

Speaker 1 [00:15:45] If I understand correctly, what you are telling me is that the difference you can observe between what you attribute as the quality of your relationship compared to some of your friends' couples, is communication on the one hand, and the ability to make efforts on the relationship because of or thanks to this deep attachment you have.

Speaker 2 [00:16:06] Yeah, to put things on the table.

Speaker 1 [00:16:09] Put things on the table.

Speaker 2 [00:16:09] To not remain silent, to avoid grudges, you see. Things you keep, that annoy you, that you sweep under the rug and then they rot inside you. And then at the next clash, that's the last straw. No, we - at least from my part and I think also from [partner]'s part, yeah this willingness to, to... Yeah effort, the term might be a bit strong, but to find common ground, to exchange and agree, in fact. Sometimes, we even write things down, we have written things down before, but to find the solution that works for everyone.

Speaker 1 [00:17:01] You are talking about your relationship compared to that of your friends. If you had to do the same, that is to compare your current relationship with that of your previous relationships. What could you say?

Speaker 2 [00:17:17] Not much. I'm [46-50] years old, so it's almost the person I've spent the most time with in my life, almost more than my own parents. The other relationships I had didn't last very, very long, a few years at best, no more. And there wasn't this complicity, the term harmony, it's true. I didn't necessarily feel this thing. And then, I think I wasn't experienced at the time, in quotes, whereas by having these previous relationships and meeting this woman who was more mature at [26-30], approaching [26-30], we move on to something else. We've finished discoveries, in fact. In the end, we are maybe... At that moment in my life and I think especially on [partner]'s side - well, she will say it herself, but we were looking to settle down, I think somewhere both of us. And it happened at the right time.

Speaker 1 [00:18:24] So if I understand correctly what you are telling me, there was a certain immaturity in you in previous relationships and maybe a way of seeing the relationship - as you say, looking to settle down - which wasn't the same, that's what changes.

Speaker 2 [00:18:39] Yeah, I think so. And then not the same harmony, it wasn't the same people. I had in my personal history, in my intimate history, I had a few girls. But stories that mattered a bit more before [partner], I had [1-5] let's say. But which for some lasted a few months, there was one that lasted a little longer, a few years. But the harmony wasn't the same, the communication wasn't the same. And then the age isn't the same. At [16-20] years old, at [16-20] years old, half big teenagers, young adults. We are not there yet. Each one is still with their parents. So it was something else. It was more for going out or saying we were with someone, or having indeed an idea of relationships in quotes, "romantic", but... It wasn't as deep and it wasn't a common life project, somehow. Whereas there, with [partner] and especially with this child who imposed themselves on us. Besides, unconsciously, we had done it, we didn't use protection. We weren't completely stupid, we knew what we were doing. So there was already, I think, something around that. Which wasn't there in previous years. There wasn't this issue, not this common project, not this story of walking a path together in the end.

Speaker 1 [00:20:09] You have mentioned harmony several times as something quite crucial in your relationship. I would like you to tell me more about it.

Speaker 2 [00:20:24] For me, the person with whom you live your life must be a bit like a pair of sneakers in which you feel comfortable. If the shoe hurts your foot, if after a few kilometers of walking you don't feel good. Something is wrong and well with [partner] I felt, yes, comfortable. And then we also brought each other professionally, in the trials we could face, in our lives, family, on both sides. We have always been somehow a support for the other. So that, it still contributes to a good harmony. We also unload on each other. I listen to her when she talks about her work, she listens to me too when I talk about my work. She is my biggest confidante, she is my biggest confidante. So yeah, I can't think of another term than harmony for us in fact. Even if sometimes there are breaks in harmony, it can happen that we sulk, have moments of questioning. But all in all, when I think about it, when I put things back in my head, I tell myself "We are in [Year], I am talking about [Year], so it's been [20-25] years". It's a bit like rain in [City], almost nonexistent, somehow. So we can rather talk about harmony.

Speaker 1 [00:21:48] If I understand correctly, harmony for you is an adequacy between two people, in this case between you and [partner], which is almost natural.

Speaker 2 [00:21:58] Yeah, we complement each other well, we miss each other when we are apart. We also know how to maintain it in the sense that we are not always, always, always glued together. Life made that we have a main home, we took a secondary house, sometimes one goes a bit ahead of the other, etc. We are not glued to each other all the time, but we always arrange to reserve time for both. We are on vacation in [City], we will finish the stay tomorrow. We've been here for [11-15] days, we have our [1-5] boys with us. They know the place, etc. They are a bit older, we trust them, but for us, it's important for us. So we had two evenings out, we left them with a phone, etc. But we needed to find each other a bit. Being with family is great, but also having moments in quotes "as a couple", simply.

Speaker 1 [00:23:00] Having moments as a couple for yourself.

Speaker 2 [00:23:03] Moments as a couple for oneself, moments where we can exchange without the children's ear... Maintaining, cultivating, exchanging between us, laughing, sometimes having more serious topics. Communicating. A lot, a lot. We talk a lot.

Speaker 1 [00:23:25] Communication.

Speaker 2 [00:23:27] Yes.

Speaker 1 [00:23:30] I would like you to tell me what is for you a high-quality relationship.

Speaker 2 [00:23:36] A high-quality relationship. For me, it's an authentic relationship, that is to say we try somehow to be as close to what we are, and to what the other person is - with their qualities and their flaws, you know. But we are no longer in the flirting stage. A low-quality relationship would be a flirting relationship. Where we show ourselves more beautiful than we are and the other also shows themselves more beautiful than they are. We sweep things under the rug, we don't talk about things that can be more disturbing, health issues, this and that. No no, we are somehow in the fantasy there. A high-quality relationship is a relationship where both people lay bare in front of each other. In fact, we know who the other is, we know what they are

made of. We also have references to their origins, where they come from, their family culture. They show us their values, what's important to them, what makes them angry, on the contrary what soothes them... Their dreams. And conversely what scares them... We know the other person. And there is no will to harm too. It's important. That is to say, if it no longer works, we stop there. But we don't go into a death struggle in this thing. Even if sometimes in arguments, it can go far. But there you go. So I would say being bare in front of the other, the other being bare in front of oneself, in a simple, direct exchange, without frills - full of affection anyway, we are not there to hurt the other. But if there are things to say, we say them and vice versa. And I think for me, a high-quality relationship is a relationship where we are authentic with the other. To what extent can we really be authentic, it's a philosophical question, but we don't cheat, you know, we don't cheat. We don't put on a show. That's it. We don't put on a show. We are what we are, the other is what they are. Yes, tell me, sorry you had a question.

Speaker 1 [00:25:49] Absolutely not, I'm listening to you.

Speaker 2 [00:25:52] Yes, I was saying we don't put on a show. We exchange simply, directly in our authenticity, in what we are, and in the moment we share, also, in the moment we share. A high-quality relationship also builds with life. For that, you need to have... Well, in my opinion. And maybe that's what one particular friend couple thought - you need moments together, you need to say things, not keep things to yourself. You also need, at some point, to wipe the slate clean, flush the toilet, I don't know what expression to use, but there you go, move on to something else not staying with grudges. Put them on the table and then move on to something else. And I think as long as you are, if you are attached to the other, if you love the other, and if you are loved by the other, that you are ready to lay bare in front of the other, not to hide things from them, to tell them what you are, there are all the reasons for it to work.

Speaker 1 [00:26:57] You talked about an authentic relationship. How can one know they are in such a relationship, in an authentic relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:27:10] Well I would say when you feel a good congruence between what the person says, what the person does, in facts, in daily life, in attentions, in little gifts, in reproaches too. You measure that, you realize that. When you are in pretense or in silence, or in avoidance, sometimes. Pass me the salt, I think of this film with [Name] and [Name], where it was a couple who hated each other in the end. There you go. Somehow the relationship is authentic too in those cases. But I would say that authenticity is the congruence between what is said, what is done and what is lived. There you go. I would say it like that, what is lived. And what is lived is still important. A couple must build its story, must have its little rituals, must have its places they love, where they like to meet. A part of secret for themselves, which they do not necessarily share with their family, with their friends, etc., which remains in intimacy. But that is what also builds complicity and, somehow, the authenticity of the couple.

Speaker 1 [00:28:32] When would you say your relationship was the most authentic?

Speaker 2 [00:28:44] Quite quickly actually, especially with this pregnancy, where we found ourselves up against the wall. Either we kept this child or we didn't, if we didn't keep it what was

there afterwards, it was hard to imagine. But she saw well that it was a big issue for me. I saw well that for her, she was much more mature, much more ready indeed to welcome a child, I think she really deeply desired it. She joked that she had found the breeding bull, so. But I think we crossed a threshold maybe indeed at that time. What would our life have been without this child coming together. We would have had a simple marital relationship, a couple without children, which could have lasted much longer. Sometimes, we wonder what will happen when the children are no longer there. Because in the end, we knew each other very little without children. But for my part, I'm not worried.

Speaker 1 [00:29:56] You're not worried.

Speaker 1 [00:29:58] No. I'm more worried about things that can happen to us: health problems, accidents, etc. That's more what worries me. The passing time, etc. Not the fact that we would separate because we don't love each other anymore. I'm not worried about that.

Speaker 1 [00:30:13] When, on the contrary, was the relationship the least authentic?

Speaker 2 [00:30:18] Ah... When there were, from my side, some deviations, a deviation, one or two deviations. I wasn't very comfortable in it. I was much younger. I think I might have been trying to prove something to myself. And then I made her suffer a lot. More than the moral fault, it was really the trust that I had broken in her that, that... Yeah, made me very sad. I questioned myself a lot about that. I really found myself... Well, that I was a jerk, there's no other term. So it really taught me a lesson. And I think that was indeed, for me, the most complicated, the most difficult moment, it was the moment indeed when this adultery - which hadn't lasted long by the way - came to light. Somehow it was also not so bad that it came out, finally that it was known and that I paid the price. Well, I wasn't comfortable there either. So yes, I would say at that time. So it happened a long time ago, it was in [Year]. It's the moment when the couple was put in danger.

Speaker 1 [00:31:40] Put in danger.

Speaker 2 [00:31:42] Hm-hm [ndt: nodding]

Speaker 1 [00:31:45] You also mentioned, in what was for you a high-quality relationship, the ability to wipe the slate clean of certain things to move on to others. I would like you to tell me more about this thing.

Speaker 2 [00:32:02] I think it applies to many areas of life. We have a bandwidth somewhere in our psyche, in our consciousness and somehow maybe also in our unconscious. But a bandwidth and sometimes, well you have to clean it a bit, you have to reset it. Keep in memory and in remembrance good moments, what builds us, what allows us, I would say, to have a bit of warmth in us when sometimes we go through more difficult moments. But grievances... There you go when something is missed we say it, and we move on to something else, and we move on to something else afterward. We flush the toilet simply. I like this expression. Really flush the toilet and hop! Not staying on unspoken things, not staying on things that put a bit of a knot in your stomach, hidden or unhealthy things that you ruminate... A kind of rumination. Avoid that

thing. Say things to each other, sometimes maybe awkwardly, but at least things are said for one as for the other. It relieves on the one hand. It relieves the one who carries the grievances. The other understands a bit more what is happening for the other half. Why they are grumpy, why they have changed their attitude, etc. And then, be ready to say things, be ready to hear them too. Sometimes it's the other way around. And you have to listen too, and then take note and say "Ok, well. On this point, I screwed up, ok. My bad". And hop, we move on to something else.

Speaker 1 [00:33:48] If I understand correctly, there are two things in this way of wiping the slate clean, of "flushing the toilet". It is both the ability to say things you don't necessarily want to say - it is once again being in an authentic relationship - but also to be able to accept them afterward. And I would like you to tell me about this ability you describe. That is to say how to indeed say things, and on the other hand be able to accept them, and then not only accept them but be able to put them aside once accepted.

Speaker 2 [00:34:18] Yes, put them aside or at least integrate them into one's reasoning. The other, well [partner], is somehow a lookout for me: she knows me. She loves me, I think, deeply, just as much as I love her so I know how she works. We are sometimes very bad judges of ourselves. We can be very hard on ourselves or on others, or be clumsy or miss things. We all have our little quirks and the other can tell us "Watch out there because you might miss or be careful, you didn't see this or that". I hear what she tells me. I record things, then I try to change my behavior, my actions accordingly. Well, if I find myself in it too because the other can also be wrong, it can happen. But I tell her at that moment, and vice versa. So yeah, being ready - I talk about laying bare, I really mean laying bare. That is to say, indeed, when we are, when we want to live a loving relationship, as soon as we really want to give ourselves to the other, yeah, we must be ready to expose ourselves and also, I would say, to accept that the other sometimes shakes things up inside us.

Speaker 1 [00:35:45] Shake things up inside us.

Speaker 2 [00:35:48] Yeah, overturn certain certainties, change points of view on things in life, on people, I would say on friends, on close ones, on family. The person we share with may sometimes need to put these origins, or people we might have placed too high... We felt there was something maybe not very balanced there, to put them back in their proper place. It can serve that purpose. The other is a lookout. And if the other tells us this, it's also for our good, not just for their own. We mustn't be instrumentalized. There you go, we mustn't be instrumentalized by the other. When the person, or when I tell [partner] things about her surroundings, or sometimes I find her harsh, and so on, I say it also a bit in her interest, at least what seems to me to be... There you go sometimes going too far or... There you go making a little feedback, simply. While leaving a significant time, while leaving the other free to decide. It's only communication.

Speaker 1 [00:37:08] Yes, leaving the other free.

Speaker 2 [00:37:10] Oh yes. Obviously. The relationship is perhaps only authentic in freedom.



Speaker 1 [00:37:18] You talked to me about what was for you a high-quality relationship. Now I would like you to tell me what is for you a low-quality relationship.

Speaker 2 [00:37:29] Oh... (sighs) A low-quality relationship... Well I would say it can be relationships in quotes "adulterous", things like that. That is to say you go for short-term pleasures generally. There is no big project around that. Unless it's polyamory, that's something else, being in several authentic relationships, but that's not my case at all. But yeah, I would say there we are in low quality, that is to say you don't expose yourself much to the other. We talk about laying bare - well there is a laying bare for the act - but beyond that, there is no laying bare. You expose little, you give little of your values, you don't tell much, you just grab what you want to grab from the other. Generally some small moments, generally I would say in quotes "sensory", and that's it. So the relationship is very, very little invested, there is no project, no desire to take a home, to go on holidays together, to want to share... Maybe a restaurant, maybe a movie, but there you go, it will stop there. Very small projects, and it stops there. A low-quality relationship is a relationship there you don't expect much, where you don't give much and where you don't receive much either. But somehow, you know that.

Speaker 1 [00:38:55] Yes, it's a relationship where you give few things.

Speaker 2 [00:39:04] Yes. And you expect little, you expect little. You are more in a conquest spirit. You are more in a... I would say in quotes - well for my part, from the male side, hetero, etc., you are more in a... A low-quality conjugal relationship, it's a girl you will pick up, period. That is to say you get her phone number, you spend a little time with her, maybe two or three, and it stops there. Besides, if that's often the problem with these things it's often that one and the other are not necessarily on the same line and one can expect more than the other and so it's quickly a mess.

Speaker 1 [00:39:47] You talked to me about things that were for you, that were part of a high-quality relationship and a low-quality relationship. Now I would like you to tell me about things, if there are others, that are most important to you in a romantic relationship.

Speaker 2 [00:40:02] So in my opinion - but well, it's also my vision, there are couples who have no libido, but as long as both have none, it can work very, very well. But I also think, as I was saying, communicate, I split the word in two and I take the vulgar side of the second part of the word. Yeah, there must also be I would say bodily relation. So sex, of course, but not only. Skin to skin, you need to see each other, you need to touch each other, you need to say nice little words, you need to kiss each other from time to time. I think of this song by [Name] "on public benches, these nascent couples who kiss", and so on. And in fact, over time, often, people drift apart. Often, people desert indeed the sexual relation which spaces out, which happens less, don't touch each other in public anymore, don't pass their hand on the back, hold hands less, don't give a little kiss. But send texts to place orders. Be careful with that. Be careful with that. So sometimes you can also be clumsy - I can be too - but there you go. I pay attention to that and I think [partner] too. We are close, we are close bodily, we still desire each other. We still have an activity and I think for me, it's important for me, I think it's also important for her. Maybe she took from me on this side. But I see it with couples who reform. Couples who separate and

reform, there are many signs of tenderness, however how long will they last... If the signs of tenderness remain over time, I think it can be a sign of longevity.

Speaker 1 [00:42:00] Signs of tenderness then.

Speaker 2 [00:42:02] Signs of tenderness, signs of affection, signs of desire. Maintain desire, too. Put eroticism in your life, not always wait for the other, but also be yourself a vector of eroticism, etc., etc. Somehow maintain the famous commu-niqué. Don't just let it come, maintain it too.

Speaker 1 [00:42:26] It's something you would place at the same level signs of affection, tenderness and sexuality.

Speaker 2 [00:42:32] Oh yes. Tenderness is part of sexuality. Sexuality is always depicted - sometimes very little affectively, it can be a bit more bestial - but even behind the bestiality, there is always a connection, there is always affection that passes through all this. So yes, in my opinion it's an important dimension unless one and the other in the couple - whatever the couple hetero, homo, etc. - if both have not invested this dimension, then it can work very well since they are both on the same level. So it can go very well.

Speaker 1 [00:43:17] You talk about this relationship with the body which is important to you. I would like you to talk a bit more about what is at play in this relationship with the body. Why is it so important? And what is its place.

Speaker 2 [00:43:30] I think in the skin to skin, the contact, the touch, the sensory in fact... Our Western world only works with images, with sight - it's important sight, seeing a nice body is great, I'm not saying porn only works with that - but hearing, smells, secretions, skin, skin texture, touch - sleeping together in the same bed is touching each other from time to time. Feeling the other close to you, it's important. I think beyond even the words, what we can say to each other, etc., holding hands is not nothing. And things happen. So, is it unconscious, big question. But I think it feeds a lot. Then, indeed it's kind of the purpose of your study I think, according to cultural codes, we touch more or less, etc., what is it like, it's a great question.

Speaker 1 [00:44:41] I would like you to tell me, based on your experience, what love is for you.

Speaker 2 [00:44:50] Big question. It remains a mystery. It remains a mystery. It's something that even turns on the side of the life drive. When you are in love with the other, you are in another state. Like when you lose love, you deeply depress. A broken heart hurts a lot. Moreover, there are passion dramas when there are broken hearts. Indeed, people can go mad and go very far when it doesn't work anymore. When it works, well, it can sublimate the person. Behind every man, there is often a woman or another man by the way. The greats of this world. I think of [Name] who said of his wife [Name], well there you go who was what she was, but he said "without you, I was nothing". But I think it deeply. Love is something, well love, affection, this harmony, what makes a couple, what can make a family afterward, this bond fills life, animates us, allows us to go through trials, allows us to say goodbyes to ancestors, etc. We still have someone with us, we have a shoulder to cry on. It's important when you are alone, well

you are alone. You can quickly fall into something else. For me, it's a, a... How to say... An essence. how could we say, I'm looking for my words. A continuum. Not a continuum, but a very important fuel for life in fact. There you go a very important fuel for life. A life without love, it's a bit sad I think. Yeah a bit sad. Then love sublimates us, allows us to surpass ourselves, allows us to see further, to see elsewhere, to see differently. It also shakes us, love, it shakes us, it shakes us in our certainties, these things make us crazier. But somehow, it makes life much warmer, much more joyful and much more sparkling. It puts color in fact, where there was gray.

Speaker 1 [00:47:09] You said "love allows us to surpass ourselves".

Speaker 2 [00:47:13] Yes, yes, yes, the other allows us to surpass ourselves, yes. The other reassures us, the other carries us, the other sometimes supports us (laughs). It's not easy sometimes. But there you go, we have someone, we have our sparring partner. It's somehow love, the couple, it's the sparring partner. It's the one with whom we will practice to then go to the outside. If the other is no longer there phew, how do we go to the outside after? It's not easy. There, we indeed have someone, when we have big news in our life, the first person we call, it's the person we share our life with. It's the first call we make. So yeah, yeah. Allows us to sublimate ourselves, allows us to surpass ourselves, allows us to go further, in fact, I think, really.

Speaker 1 [00:48:15] To go further.

Speaker 2 [00:48:16] To go further and then to open our reflections, to change our points of view... The other is still an alterity, a harmonious relationship, sure, but well, the other is still different from oneself. But it's good that they are different from oneself somehow too, it allows us to move forward.

Speaker 1 [00:48:36] You talk interchangeably about the other and love. Love for you is the other. And not love as a concept. Love is embodied when you talk about it.

Speaker 2 [00:48:50] So for me, it's conjugal love that I take because there are other forms of love. Friendship is a form of love. Parental love is a love, and so on. There are several forms of love. But there, I was on conjugal love. Love, the love, the big heart, and so on, that I associate - well when you talk to me about love the first thing that comes to mind is my companion, the couple, and so on. When I think of love, I think of that. The other forms of love exist, it's affection, it's affectivity, it's somehow love, a deep friendship, a friend, it's somehow a love that didn't happen. It's someone who knows us. Well, there was a nice expression actually, wait I remembered it, I need to find it. "A friend is someone who really knows us, but who still tolerates us". "Who loves us anyway" sorry. "Who really knows us, but who loves us anyway". So there you go. And indeed, love, it's still - if we took a kind of Maslow pyramid, well conjugal love is the one at the top of the pyramid. The base of the pyramid being rather, in the person's history, being the affective bond, how they were carried by their own parents, especially by their mother, and so on. We could do something like that. And conjugal love in my representation would be the top of the pyramid.

Speaker 1 [00:50:27] Yes, it's also a love where you are maybe almost - if I understood correctly what you are telling me - even more in a form of authenticity, even more laid bare, even more supportive than other relationships since these are relationships...

Speaker 2 [00:50:46] Yes. In other relationships, there are others. Of course, there is intimacy, but I would say, there are others, there is the rest of the family, there are other friends. We don't necessarily see each other all the time. We never really have time to see each other. Whereas in conjugal love, we see each other, we live together. Well in my opinion. Even if we can have moments, of course, where one and the other have other activities where we keep a little space also, a little for ourselves, but we are mainly with the other. The other is always present in our mind. There isn't a day that goes by without us having a thought for the other. Whereas we can have many days, we don't necessarily think about our friends, our parents, and so on.

Speaker 1 [00:51:35] It's the relationship that takes up the most space, and the most important one.

Speaker 2 [00:51:40] Yes, the most important. The first one. The first one. You see, if you were asked the question "with whom would you go to a desert island?", I would say with [partner], with one person, it would be my companion, of course.

Speaker 1 [00:51:55] We know there are different forms and ways of loving, but I would like you to tell me how you know your partner loves you.

Speaker 2 [00:52:04] Because she tells me. Because she shows me, regularly. Because I know I matter to her. It makes me proud, by the way. Yeah, through her words, and through her attentions. For example, I like strong alcohols. Well, everyone has their thing - and we didn't have much left at home - and [partner] went shopping the other day. We're in [City] now. She went with our eldest son, and she bought a bottle of goutte [a type of alcohol] for me. I told her "But you paid a fortune for that," "No, no, no," she said, "No, no. We didn't have any left, I know you like it." Well, there you go. And she never drinks it, she's not interested in that. She's not interested. If she puts a little drop in a coffee with me to please me, there you go, to help digest a bit, but she doesn't drink it, it's not her thing. Clearly. I mean, if she wasn't with me, she would never buy it. And yet she spends money on it. And she spends money for me. What is that if not a proof of love. She has no interest in doing that for me. She does it because she knows it will make me happy and she is proud, moreover, to do it. Just like I have signs of attention towards her. Before we left for [City], I went to [Store Name] to buy some things. If you want, you need a small pair of shoes to go to the beach, all that. Sneakers are a pain, flip-flops are not great, so I know she doesn't really like espadrilles, a bit of sandals with straps that cling, that old German thing. She's not a fan of that. But I went to [Store Name], I went to other stores before, I took pictures, I sent pictures, I told her which one do you want, this one or that one. I wanted to get her one, but one that she liked the most, what. Which seemed the most suitable, we even discussed it for a while in the store, because there was this model, that model and she told me "no actually this one is tip top." She wears them almost every day now. And there you go. I don't care if she wears sandals or not actually. It's more practical, it suits her better. And there you go,

a little attention for her, period. Well, there you go, that I get her a little something. It makes me happy. And it makes me happy to make her happy.

Speaker 1 [00:54:36] If I understand correctly, these signs of attention are the efforts we make because we want to please the other.

Speaker 2 [00:54:45] Yeah, it's not even efforts, it's natural. It's not an effort, it goes without saying. It's almost a pleasure to do it. We do it for the other. We're happy to offer them a little something. There you go, it's a proof, a proof of love, a sign of attention. And then we take something that pleases the other. There you go. Like the little drop [a type of alcohol] she got me.

Speaker 1 [00:55:09] Like the drop.

Speaker 2 [00:55:11] Yes.

Speaker 1 [00:55:13] I'd like you to tell me about one of the latest positive interactions you've had with your partner.

Speaker 2 [00:55:19] Well, earlier, at the beach. This morning we woke up quite early, had a coffee, then [partner] went back to sleep. I let her sleep a bit more, and we had planned to go to a beautiful beach here, at [inaudible] - it's not very far from here, 20 minutes by car - very clear water, etc. But since she went back to sleep, the boys woke up a bit later, there's a small ping pong table but it's starting to be in the sun, and then [partner] came to join us. But she was still think upset because she slept a bit longer. And then we were in full sun, we were still playing, we didn't have sunscreen, we weren't wearing hats, we weren't wearing t-shirts, so she arrived still angry saying "no no, we stop." So we sulked a bit for maybe a good hour. And at some point, she came to me when we were swimming, and I wasn't saying anything, we were sulking a bit - well not badly - but we were sulking a bit anyway. And she came to me, and I said "Well do you have something to say?" she said "You also have something to say?", we apologized to each other. And there, I saw her face transform. I found her, I found her. She came to me, she stretched her arms, she spread her legs she hugged me, we had water up to our chests both of us, the kids were further away, she kissed me, she put her tongue in my mouth and there you go, it's simple. It's simple, I can't tell you otherwise. I was very happy, she too then. The return trip went much better, and so on and so forth. So there you go, it's simple things like that.

Speaker 1 [00:56:52] I would like you to tell me, on the contrary, about one of the latest negative interactions you've had with your partner.

Speaker 2 [00:57:02] Oh no, what could it have been? Because they are often small disputes. But maybe a bigger dispute we had a few months ago about housing issues. [partner] lost her dad last year, he was in [city], he had a place. She didn't really know what to do with this place because he had - so she has a sister, they both inherited a share of this place, a T3 in [city]. I had a lot of affection for my father-in-law, and I thought it was stupid to sell that apartment. It's a beautiful apartment, well located, etc. And I said "Listen, you buy the half-share. Your sister is not interested, I'm willing to put money into it, it's not a problem" and so on. She didn't really

know, she did it indeed, but I don't know... Maybe a bit reluctantly. So, there were still some resistances about redoing it, whether we were going to move into it or not,... So there was some hesitation. Now, things are much clearer. We know we're going to move in, we've redone things inside, we're going to continue to do things inside, it will keep us busy for the second half of the year. But there was some hesitation I want to tell you. Yeah at the end of last year, end of [Year]. I spent a lot of time emptying it, I had committed to emptying this apartment, removing things, etc. I spent a lot of time on it. I saw she was dragging her feet. I understood her position at the same time, I was much more external than her compared to her father. So it's easier for me to remove things. For her, it's much more painful. I understood it well, but it still somewhat distanced us, saddened us a bit. Because I think she wasn't very comfortable with it. I also felt a bit guilty for maybe forcing her hand, but at the same time I thought it was stupid to let it go. There was something at stake both with her family history at the same time as I was stepping into it. And then, at the same time, a bit of a real estate, economic interest mixed with all that, so yeah, a bit of static on the line, it wasn't easy. But we talked about it, we talked about it, and we still talk about it. Which allows us again to move forward, to say things when we need to say them and then to continue, to continue the journey.

Speaker 1 [00:59:29] I would like you to tell me, in your opinion, about the challenges to face in your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:59:35] Challenges to face. Hmm... Yeah, as I was telling you, what will happen when the nest is empty. We're approaching [46-50], we still have [1-5] kids, [11-15] and [11-15] years old. But in [6-10] years, what will - we joked that we want to grow old together, actually. We said it jokingly, but I think we mean what we say. But when we will really be just the two of us, all the time, won't that be the challenge to face? I don't know. I'm not very worried, but I think, maybe the empty nest syndrome could indeed affect us.

Speaker 1 [01:00:24] There are also challenges you have already overcome in your relationship.

Speaker 2 [01:00:29] Yes, yes, yes, we have indeed overcome that adultery that happened a few years ago. We overcame it, yeah. It was a challenge, it was complicated, but we overcame it, I think.

Speaker 1 [01:00:49] There are things you mentioned a few times during the interview, we know that sometimes, in a relationship, everything is not rosy, and I would like you to talk about the conflicts or disputes you can have with your partner.

Speaker 2 [01:01:02] Oh, well... Often I think, I think we need, a bit like a pressure cooker, to release the pressure. At least for my part. And I think I take it out on her, she didn't ask for anything. But because I must have some annoyance, maybe some anxiety, some nervousness. Sometimes, I take it out on her a bit and I think that sometimes, it annoys her. She points it out to me, so I pay attention. But there for example for the holidays, it's going very well. Except for that little incident this morning. But there you go, we argue little. So, there may indeed be that which can occasionally degrade, yeah, our relationship. And she too can sometimes be in a bad

mood, sometimes not very cordial and very pleasant with me. So I get angry too. Sometimes I understand her, it depends. But sometimes I get angry too. So there you go. It can be annoyance that quickly turns into disputes, but which upset us both. So quite quickly, we have never - we haven't left each other for a few days for things like that. No, that has never happened.

Speaker 1 [01:02:27] I would like you to tell me maybe a bit more about the subject of these disputes.

Speaker 2 [01:02:37] It's really a good question. I try to find what could... Because it often seems futile to me. Reproaches, maybe. I reproach her maybe sometimes for not following up on papers too much, for not following up on things too much, leaving me a bit alone to deal with it - so it's, yeah, reproaches I can make on that side. Sending her back to her corner saying "But there you go, you manage nothing, everything is fine, it's easy, and so on, and it's me who does everything." I'm in bad faith, of course, it's not true. But there you go I can sometimes make a bit of an accusation.

Speaker 1 [01:03:16] How often would you say these conflicts, these disputes or these little hiccups occur, over a fortnight, what would it be?

Speaker 2 [01:03:26] Ah well there, it's not representative, because we are on vacation. So except for this morning we didn't argue much. Ah I want to say maybe we have a little argument once a month.

Speaker 1 [01:03:39] Once a month.

Speaker 2 [01:03:42] Once or twice, once or twice a month, I would say yeah, it can happen like that. But we had sometimes more violent disputes in the past, but it seems less, it seems less in the last [1-5] years. Maybe we were also preoccupied with the end of my father-in-law's life, so it might have brought us closer.

Speaker 1 [01:04:06] You mentioned other disputes, which might have been more significant.

Speaker 2 [01:04:12] Oh... When I recall there, there was, [redacted]. So there you go, I think of that, but otherwise, I don't see more things like that.

Speaker 1 [01:05:21] Not more things that can lead to conflicts or disputes.

Speaker 2 [01:05:26] Yeah, it will rather be annoyances, let's say. Annoyances that flare up.

Speaker 1 [01:05:33] Annoyances that flare up.

Speaker 2 [01:05:35] Yeah. But not - not factual reasons. Neither she nor I have, how to say, the will to harm the other. There are no bad tricks, that's what I meant to say. There are no bad tricks. So there are no disputes. There can be, but it remains in quotes, on the surface and quite

futile, and somehow, rather to be considered as a kind of cyclothymic functioning, where for the sun to come back sometimes it has to rain.

Speaker 1 [01:06:16] You talk to me about these conflicts, the disputes you can have. You told me about their subjects, their frequency. How do you - how do you - resolve these conflicts.

Speaker 2 [01:06:29] By discussing them. By finding already a common ground with the other. Already to be able to discuss, to talk, but without attacking each other, sometimes by finding mediation solutions. On the story of the housing, so in [city], of the father-in-law that we are going to take back, and then the rental we had, etc., well we had to indeed go through writing, we write things, we signed a paper both of us, giving ourselves a deadline. And indeed, sometimes, I find it's a good solution because we go through writing. And we sign, and we commit to it and so, it's noted.

Speaker 1 [01:07:16] Through writing.

Speaker 2 [01:07:19] Through writing, yes. It was, I think, especially on this little dispute recently. But the last dispute that comes to mind, well, the most open and important conflict where it was the most complicated for both of us, is this story of the father-in-law's apartment what we were doing with it, whether we were selling it, renting it, taking it for ourselves, etc. We had, I think, very divergent views on that and we exchanged between us, and we found, we find solutions. That is to say, I was more of the opinion indeed, we should stop renting and move into this apartment, especially since we have a country house. But on the other hand, I told [partner] "The counterpart, I understand, is that you also want to enjoy life a bit which is also understandable, you don't necessarily want to live in your father's apartment, we will renovate it, etc. so we will do the necessary work, etc. we have a country house but above all the money we will no longer spend on rent, well now we will put it in a small vehicle. There you go we will maybe have it slightly fitted out - it won't be a camper, we don't have the money - but a little thing so we can wander around a bit, while we are still in our [46-50], go on little trips, a night in a hotel, a night in the thing, there you go." And so, it was how to turn divergent visions into a common desire. So find a solution, a mediation, where everyone is satisfied somewhere where everyone is satisfied. And I think we, she and I, have that in mind. Not necessarily imposing one's will on the other, but not submitting to the other either. So find the right solution so that everyone is satisfied.

Speaker 1 [01:09:05] You talked about forms of mediation and especially writing in this case what does writing, in this context or in others, bring to mediation?

Speaker 2 [01:09:20] Well, first it has a strong symbolic value. That is to say, we write, there are two copies, we each keep one. There you go, we note with a date, a place, what we plan to do. We can give ourselves a deadline, it's like a contract somewhere. It's a contract, that we sign for ourselves and that we sign with the other. And it symbolically engages. And through writing, there you go, we silence, in quotes, the comments of this or that. There you go, we sit around a table, we agree. If the version does not suit one or the other, they will keep annoying us. So we



renegotiate to find the best contract that suits both. And yeah, I think it's indeed a good - well it seems to me to be both symbolically and in form, a good solution.

Speaker 1 [01:10:14] Besides the things you described to me, that is communication, mediation. What are the other ways you maintain your relationship?

Speaker 2 [01:10:30] Yeah, attentions, shared time together. We spend time both.. Sometimes [partner] reproached me, when we had taken a small secondary residence house, she reproached me for doing a lot of things in a garden and thus neglecting her a bit with the kids, etc., that, I heard it, and so, there you go, I do a bit less in the garden, and so I'm a bit more present with her. So there you go, it's also giving each other time as a family, but also as a couple. Going out, having a little restaurant. Sharing something, what.

Speaker 1 [01:11:15] Sharing something.

Speaker 2 [01:11:17] Sharing something. And I come back to it, maintaining desire, maintaining the couple. Having an intimate activity, for me it's important, I think for [partner] too. It binds us. A lot.

Speaker 1 [01:11:34] I'd like to know what could make you leave your partner.

Speaker 2 [01:11:40] Ah. if uh... If I no longer had value in her eyes. That is to say if at some point her gaze turns elsewhere, I don't see what I could stay for indeed. Or if at some point I no longer feel anything for her either. I think out of honesty, even if it's not... There you go, I think it could be that. I mainly think that what would make it not work between us, is that one of us simply - which can happen in life - would die a violent death. I think of death.

Speaker 1 [01:12:28] Would you say this relationship is good for you.

Speaker 2 [01:12:31] Oh yes. Oh yes. I would not be as balanced in my life. I would not have succeeded in my professional career if [partner] had not been with me. It's obvious.

Speaker 1 [01:12:49] You talk about balance.

Speaker 2 [01:12:51] Oh yes. Yes yes. Balance and success. Personal success, material success. She obviously contributed to it.

Speaker 1 [01:13:04] I would like you to give me an example of this balance you describe, that is to say, if I understand correctly, the ability to regulate daily functioning through the other or through the relationship.

Speaker 2 [01:13:15] Yeah. It's not a love in which I feel imprisoned either, huh. I remain free, I do what I have to do. But I know I can count on her. She is present in my mind. When there is important news, she is the first person I contact. If there is good news to share it is obviously with her that I do it. Yeah, she is my other half, she is my other half. I have no other words.

Speaker 1 [01:14:06] You talk to me about this harmony, this balance. Do you have moments, a particular moment where you think indeed she had this role you describe, of balance, of balancing you.

Speaker 2 [01:14:34] I think for example of relationships, at work, work relationships, especially relationships with the hierarchy. I have had sometimes frustrations, there you go, things where I didn't always find myself. And well, she had this perspective, she wasn't in the situation, but she had the perspective to be calm, to bring another view, another way of looking at things that led me to position myself differently. And I think I found myself much more.

Speaker 1 [01:15:17] I'd like to know if you think you are the same person as before your current relationship. In other words, has this relationship changed you?

Speaker 2 [01:15:24] Oh yes. Oh yes, yes. I am no longer the same man. I think I have aged well. I don't know how to say it, but I feel better in my skin today, at [46-50] years old than at [26-30] when I met her for example. There you go. Because she fills me, she, the relationship we have indeed together. Before, I had other people, but it's no comparison. It's no comparison. Like a, like a... How to say. Like a cheap red wine type la villageoise and then a very good Burgundy, what. It's no comparison.

Speaker 1 [01:16:26] Regarding your partner, your companion. Do you think she has changed during and in relation to the relationship.

Speaker 2 [01:16:33] You'd have to ask her. I imagine yes, at least that's what she tells me. That's what she tells me. I think she is more fulfilled, I imagine too. But she will tell you, I think she finds herself in it, indeed.

Speaker 1 [01:16:50] Do you feel safe in this relationship?

Speaker 2 [01:16:57] Yes, yes, yes. Yes and I think I take on much more in my life because of this relationship.

Speaker 1 [01:17:06] It's therefore a supportive relationship.

Speaker 2 [01:17:09] Supportive. Yeah supportive. And then... So supportive yes, and then, I would also say, an important point - well I believe. The couple is also an economic union, it's also an economic union. So we live our lives better, we are more comfortable, we have a bit more material means, we have an emotional security. Well, it still sets the bar at a good level, I would say on the happiness scale in life. When you are alone, you bear the costs alone. You have more or less emotional insecurity, you can manage with a few things but well. It's still not the same. But economically, it's not the same story.

Speaker 1 [01:18:03] You talked about emotional security and feeling safe in a relationship, that can be for example knowing that you can get comfort or attention from the other in case of danger or distress.

Speaker 2 [01:18:22] Oh yes, absolutely. Absolutely. I think if something bad happened to me, a great sorrow, I think she would be there to support me. I deeply believe it.

Speaker 1 [01:18:43] Is it something that has already happened.

Speaker 2 [01:18:47] Not with her. I had other sorrows indeed before, but not with her, for now we haven't had - I knock on wood - great misfortunes actually, well on my level on my side. But if it were to happen, I would lean on her, well I think I can lean on her.

Speaker 1 [01:19:07] There's also something else in security, it's something you've mentioned several times during the interview, especially at the beginning. It's this ability to open up to your partner about your experiences, your thoughts, your identity without fear of judgment or retaliation, in other words to be yourself. The authenticity you talked about, it's also something you find in this relationship.

Speaker 2 [01:19:34] Oh yes. And I think it's easier to be authentic at [50-55] than at [16-20] because at [16-20], we don't really know who we are in fact, ultimately. It's with the years that we know ourselves a little better, at least, that we have a bit more experience. So, we observe ourselves a bit more, we see ourselves aging, we see things changing around us, so we affirm our tastes a bit. Whereas, at the beginning, we don't really know. We copy, or we go a bit by feeling, but often we make mistakes. We don't know ourselves well. I see it, through psychology too, thanks [Name], we know ourselves better, we understand ourselves better at least. But however, I never had any discomfort with [partner] and I think moreover, I don't know - well that's a good question - I don't know if I could do that with someone else, to be as comfortable actually. What [partner] tells me, huh. "With you, I tell you everything". (laughs) She says "I don't know if with someone else I could be like that actually". Being oneself. It's true that we know each other well, we allow ourselves, we have no worries. It strengthens us.

Speaker 1 [01:21:02] If I understand correctly what you are telling me, there is obviously this notion of being authentic, being oneself. But in the first part of what you just told me there is also this idea that to be oneself, you also need to know who you are.

Speaker 2 [01:21:15] Yes, you need to know yourself. The other can help us to know ourselves better too. But you also need to know how to look in the mirror, you also need to be introspective, and self-reflective. By the deformation of studies and the job, well yes, I am led to it, but I share it and I completely reveal it to [partner]. She knows who I am and I think seeing my face, she knows what happens to me. And vice versa. I can guess without her speaking from the shape of her face if things are going well, if there's something bothering her, etc. We feel it, we see it, we sniff it. We have tamed each other like animals.

Speaker 1 [01:22:15] You told me that even if you inscribed yourself in this security, that is to say the fact that you can have attention and comfort in case of problem, danger, etc., you didn't necessarily have an example in mind. Do you have an example of this ability to open up, to be oneself, about thoughts, identity that you could share with me.

Speaker 2 [01:22:39] Hmm... Maybe also in moments of emotion. I'm rather a modest person - I'm very immodest, I like dirty jokes, etc., I'm topless at the beach, I don't care, well there you go, I have a crappy car. There are plenty of things where I don't care. But on my inner joys, my inner sorrows, I express little. I rarely tell people I have affection for them. I'm not very comfortable with that. And when [partner] lost her dad, it made me really, really sad and I cried with her. Which is quite rare. You see it still brings tears to my eyes. But I told her "You know, for me, he was... Well he was someone I loved a lot because I think he loved me too". And there, well - it didn't lessen her sorrow of course not - but there you go. I didn't do it to please her. I told her the sorrow I felt, that I still feel a bit. About this man who was, as I say, a father-in-law, but really in both good words, really a father-in-law. And yeah, I... It's only with her that I reveal myself like that. With my other friends at work, with people around me, I don't reveal myself as much. I say a lot of nonsense, I like to talk about many things, I can talk about multiple subjects, I'm a big talker. But rather silent about what concerns me. Well political opinions all that, sure, no problem. But about what I feel, about who I am deeply, about what makes me react, about what hurts me, about what displeases me, not much. But with [partner] I tell her. She feels it, I think. She knows what makes me happy, what touches me, yeah. She knows me. As I know her.

Speaker 1 [01:24:57] Knowing each other.

Speaker 2 [01:24:59] Knowing each other. Knowing the other. Even if he is always a bit apart, even if he is - the human being is always a bit apart so we can wait - but quite quickly we find each other, we find him again or at least we know where he is going.

Speaker 1 [01:25:15] If I understand correctly, there is also this notion that is very important, to be in a supportive and helpful relationship, and which is also in a place of security, a safe space, a place where we can really express, even if we have...

Speaker 2 [01:25:34] Yes, absolutely. A soul space for two, an intimate space where things happen indeed, that concern only the two.

Speaker 1 [01:25:48] I would now like to address another constitutive dimension of couple relationships that you mentioned during the interview, it's sexuality. We know it can be a more or less important dimension in a relationship. What is it like for you, for you and for both of you.

Speaker 2 [01:26:04] It's an important dimension for me, but I think also for her. So there, with the holidays we make love every day. But yes, it's a rich dimension, that we don't neglect, there you go, that we don't neglect.

Speaker 1 [01:26:37] That we don't neglect.

Speaker 2 [01:26:41] No. We always enjoy playing together, enjoying together. We have our practices, they concern us. We have our sexual history indeed to us.

Speaker 1 [01:27:09] You said that currently you sleep together every day. More generally, what would be roughly the frequency of your relations.

Speaker 2 [01:27:19] The relations? I would say several times a week. Several times a week, 2 to 3 times a week. Sometimes in the daily work life, and so on, the fatigue means maybe a bit less. But I don't think we ever went days without making love.

Speaker 1 [01:27:43] Would you say you are satisfied with your sex life.

Speaker 2 [01:27:47] Oh yes! Yes, yes, yes. It has even amplified with the years.

Speaker 1 [01:27:55] So why would you say you are satisfied, and it has amplified.

Speaker 2 [01:28:06] We were already - So wait, I'm taking the phone because people have arrived in the mobile home, people have returned. So I'm going outside, hold on. You don't move, but I move.

Speaker 2 [01:29:30] That's it. I'm outside. So now, there is another setting, I was in the bedroom and now my partner and the kids have returned - it must be snack time or something like that. Anyway, they have returned. So it's me who goes outside. So yes I was telling you, yes we were already - well when we met in [Year], not the first night, but the second night we were already sleeping together. What I really appreciated about her is that she was a sexually active woman and it suited me well, I am too. We have always maintained that indeed. And since, yes, I would say maybe [6-10] years, we have entered a bit into libertinism which means we have, yeah, cultivated, how to say... Strengthened, expanded the painter's palette. I like that expression. From three colors we have come to a few more colors, and it also makes a secret because it's something we keep for - nobody knows except you now, suddenly. There you go. But it also contributes to our affection, to our complicity, to the strengthening, somehow, of the couple.

Speaker 1 [01:30:50] Listen, I'm going to share my screen. I'm going to show you two items from a scale and I would like you to answer these two items, give me your opinion. So you tell me when you see it.

Speaker 2 [01:31:07] So wait I need to zoom. Oh damn I don't see - I'm going to turn the screen because it's a bit small. So. Generally, my partner really listens to me.

Speaker 1 [01:31:17] There you go. Generally, my partner really listens to me on a scale from 1 to 9.

Speaker 2 [01:31:22] Moderately, very true, completely... Completely is really the ideal thing. We'll put 8. 9 is still a bit perfect. Let's say eight and a half.

Speaker 1 [01:31:34] So why eight.

Speaker 2 [01:31:38] Uh... Does nine exist already? (laughs) It's like the gymnastics thing, you know, [Name] who had 10 out of 10 or 20 out of 20 in the [Event] in [field], well the perfect score may not necessarily exist. But generally, yeah, my partner listens to me that's clear, it's more than very true. We're not far from completely. But does completely exist, does the other.... So,

do we not say to ourselves somewhere that we represent it like that. But well, there are plenty of signs that show me that she really listens to me. So eight and a half, between eight and nine.

Speaker 1 [01:32:18] My partner is generally attentive to my needs, on this same scale. Where would you place yourself.

Speaker 2 [01:32:23] Attentive to my needs? Yeah she is attentive. Maybe a little less... Yeah 7, very true.

Speaker 1 [01:32:31] So why seven.

Speaker 2 [01:32:34] She is attentive to my needs, but she also has hers. She is not, how to say. She is not an object of my desires, my impulses, and so on. So there you go, she is attentive. Yes, yes, to my needs. She knows what pleases me, she strives to do things indeed, but, she also has her own life, huh. So yeah seven, seven.

Speaker 1 [01:32:59] So why not six or why not eight.

Speaker 2 [01:33:04] Six or five. That would mean that... I wouldn't find her, we would be more distant then, no. Above, she wouldn't exist. She has her own personality, let's not forget. She is attentive to my needs, yes, but she also has her needs. She doesn't forget herself. Just as I don't forget myself.

Speaker 1 [01:33:30] How satisfied are you with your relationship? It goes from completely dissatisfied, very dissatisfied, somewhat dissatisfied, uncertain/neutral, somewhat satisfied, very satisfied or completely satisfied.

Speaker 2 [01:33:43] Very satisfied. My romantic relationship with [partner], very satisfied. So there, compared to the wording of the question, very.

Speaker 1 [01:33:52] You just answered in a verbal form. If we switched to a numerical form, that is to say that zero would be not at all satisfied and ten completely satisfied, where would you place yourself.

Speaker 2 [01:34:02] Degree of satisfaction, huh? My degree of satisfaction? I am - let's say 9 and a half or 10. But for once you see I have fewer scruples to say ten. My degree of satisfaction with my relationship with [partner], yeah it's 10.

Speaker 1 [01:34:20] Compared to...

Speaker 2 [01:34:21] To what I expect from it. Her presence, her attentions, this life spent together... Yeah, yeah. My degree of satisfaction with the romantic relationship I have with this woman, yes it is - you see we talked about the other relationships I might have had, which go back a bit in time suddenly - yes there is really no comparison.

Speaker 1 [01:34:49] Completely satisfied for you.

Speaker 2 [01:34:50] Completely satisfied.

Speaker 1 [01:34:53] Why not eight.

Speaker 2 [01:34:56] Oh well eight wouldn't be representative of what I think. Eight would mean there would be a bit of reserve or there would be things... So maybe yes, because we reconciled earlier, this and that. If you had asked me the question when we were sulking a bit, I would have said eight. I would have said eight because we were sulking. (laughs) I would have said eight because I was sulking at her and she was sulking at me. There you go. But we have this interview in a context - I told you I'm on vacation, we've been in [City] for [11-15] days, we have the kids it's going well... Sea, Sex and Sun. So, the vision of the satisfaction of our relationship, our relationship is very good currently.

Speaker 1 [01:35:50] Very well. Listen, we're approaching the end of the interview. Is there anything you would like to add, clarify, correct? Maybe a dimension that seems important to you. You can take the time to reflect.

Speaker 2 [01:36:05] Hmmm... Well, it's the first time I talk so much about [partner] to someone I don't know. So there you go, it's a particular exercise, but after all... No, I have nothing, there's nothing I want to come back on or correct. No, I would add nothing. I would just say that I - I don't know which Greek philosopher said that, when we fall on the planet we fall in the form of a ball that breaks in two and that the goal of our life is to find the other half of the ball. If that thing held true, was true, I think I found the half.

Speaker 1 [01:36:52] Very well. I will stop the recording now.